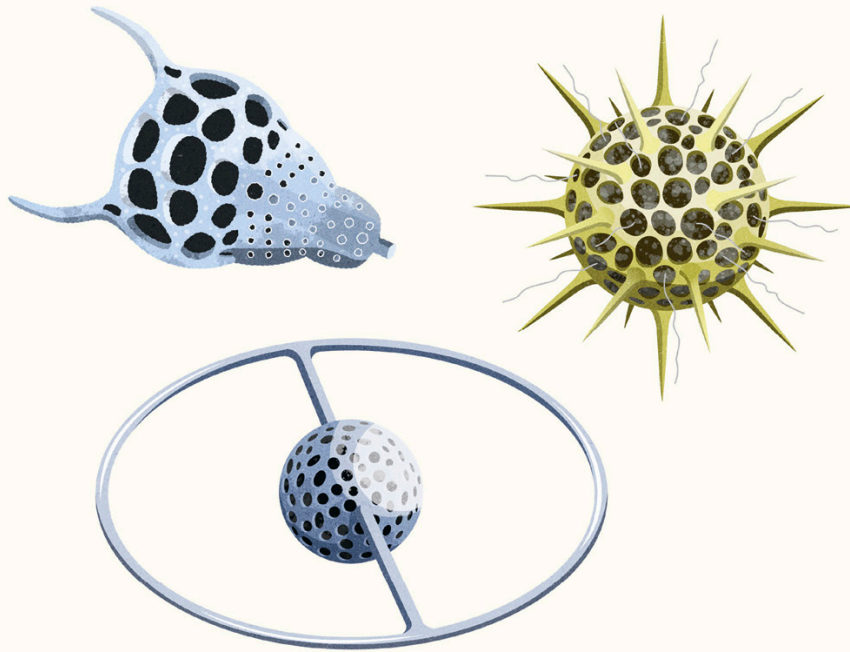


Some radiolarians have spines that help them float in the water. The spines are delicate and easily broken though.



Radiolarian

The amazing shells of these microscopic life forms look like they could be made of glass, and that's because they are! Inside each glass house is a soft organism called a radiolarian (ray-dee-oh-lair-ee-an). Each one of these organisms builds a delicate skeleton from silica, which is what glass is made of.

Radiolarians live in the ocean. To eat, they poke bits of their blobby body out of the holes in their cage-like shell to grab passing prey. When radiolarians die, their hollow frame remains. Some resemble stars, and others golf balls, spaceships, or even the planet Saturn. What do you think they look like?